Then, in May 1970, Mao's greeting to the Indian chargé Brajesh Mishra at the May Day celebrations sparked hope that Chinese policymakers might be rethinking their India policy. Mishra reported that Mao told him, "We cannot keep on quarrelling like this. We should try and be friends again.… We will be friends again some day." The chargé reported that he responded, "We are ready to do it today." He did not know whether Mao's comments were premeditated, but, given the source, recommended that they be given "the most weighty consideration."[85] Subsequently, the head of China's Asia department said that Mao had taken "the greatest concrete action on our side" and now India should take some steps. Beijing, he said, had noticed the talk from India, but not seen "concrete action."[86]

Haksar believed the "Mao smile" to have "some significance," but suggested to the prime minister that they "must not rush to any conclusions" and handle the matter "very delicate[ly] and tentative[ly]." Always conscious of Soviet sensitivities, he was reluctant to recommend—as the foreign minister did—that Mishra seek to meet with high-level officials in Beijing.[87] Others like Natwar Singh, a diplomat in the prime minister's office (and a future foreign minister), cautioned against a "hasty" reaction or any grand public response at that stage.[88] Haksar was also hesitant about the foreign minister's suggestion of a letter from Gandhi to Zhou suggesting a meeting with Mishra and eventually an exchange of ambassadors.[89] Gandhi took Haksar's advice, and the chargé was instructed to follow a "cautious and step by step approach." He should meet China's Asia department chief to convey India's "sincere and positive" response and willingness to "initiate a dialogue with the object of removing the state of tension and hostility" on the basis of "mutuality and reciprocity."[90]

The Indian chargé pressed for more, arguing that there were further positive signals from China.[91] He noted that Beijing had "displayed what for them is moderation" in rhetoric during a visit by the Pakistan Air Force chief, and furthermore seemed to have made the chief tone down his vitriol. In July, Zhou conveyed his regards to Gandhi. Chinese officials also indicated to Asian diplomats that they were trying to normalize relations with a number of countries and intended to do the same with India. The North Vietnamese ambassador in Beijing told Mishra that China was impressed with some Indian actions that indicated Indian independence from the US—dialoguing with deposed Cambodian leader Norodom